hand'.[91] The report further mentioned the unhappiness of partisans over Menon, Lambah, Ansari, and Gharekhan's conciliatory advocacy. Lambah, who had been present at the 2001 Bonn conference and was known for his back-channel prowess with Pakistan, had been appointed as PM's special envoy to Afghanistan and Pakistan in 2005 (a move to 'rationalise' India's bureaucracy) in order to bring pragmatism to relations with Pakistan.[92] Though he could not break bureaucratic logjams, he increased the conciliators' strength within the bureaucracy. Partisans (including X) could not prevent India's policy shift, and all further diplomatic energy was focused on crafting a reconciliation strategy that would ensure Afghanistan's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Former Afghan President Burhanuddin Rabbani, who was appointed as the key negotiator with the Afghan Taliban, visited India in September 2011 at New Delhi's request, and had a long meeting with R. S. Pandey, India's principle interlocutor with the Naga separatist outfit National Socialist Council of Nagaland (NSCN).[93] Having fought various insurgencies in Kashmir, Punjab, and the northeast, New Delhi had a wealth of counterinsurgency (COIN) expertise to share with Kabul. Respecting 'red lines' such as accepting the Afghan constitution and giving-up violence were preconditions to such talks, Pandey advised Rabbani.[94] India's approach towards reconciliation was in stark contrast with how the coalition forces, especially Britain, envisaged it (leading to a standoff between London and New Delhi). In October 2011 India signed the Strategic Partnership Agreement (SPA) with Afghanistan and officially accepted an Afghan-owned, Afghan-led, and Afghan-controlled transition.[95]

The partisans challenged this conciliatory strategy vehemently. X remembers that India's 'game' was going well until the time Narayanan was NSA, but it went downhill after Menon's appointment. 'Bizarre' orders about talking to the Afghan Taliban started coming from Menon and Chidambaram's office, which X and his colleagues listened to but didn't, and couldn't, do much about. 'They were far from realities', X says disdainfully.[96] Menon used to give a patient hearing to the R&AW's assessments and debriefs about what the agency's Afghanistan and Pakistan desk officers were doing, but never gave clear directions like Narayanan or Brajesh Mishra. X remembers having many meetings with Menon, in which 'he [Menon] would listen and then at the end say, "let's try and accommodate the